



Contemporary World History · 1st year of Bachillerato · The historian's craft · Class 2 of 6 · With Tristán

Workshop: a day in the archive



Class video: https://youtu.be/lG505Tq_aBg

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Before you start: your bet

The 1918 flu is called the "Spanish flu". Why do you think it was given that name? Tick one and explain why in one sentence.

1. Because it started in Spain.

2. Because it was worse in Spain.

3. For another reason (which one?).

At the end of the class. Did you get it right? Which clue would have made you change your bet?

While you watch the video

1. To find out what the 1918 newspapers said, which door do you knock on: archive, newspaper library, museum or interpretation centre? Why?
2. Two tricks for searching a digital newspaper library. What are they?
3. Does the *El Liberal* article of 21 May 1918 say "Spanish flu"? What does it call it?
4. What evidence does the *Seattle Star* article give that the Germans sowed the flu? Is it really evidence?

The research sheet

The *El Liberal* article (Madrid, 21 May 1918, p. 2). Next to each answer, mark how you know: **S** (I see it), **R** (a record or source says so), **C** (I infer it from the context) or **?** (it's not known).

Question	Answer	How do I know?
Who made it?		
When and where?		
What for?		
For whom?		
What does it tell without meaning to?		

Fact or interpretation?

Mark **F** (fact, the sources say so) or **I** (interpretation). If it is an interpretation, is it well supported or not? Why?

1. *El Liberal* of 21 May 1918 calls the epidemic "the fashionable illness".
2. The flu was called "Spanish" because the Spanish press reported it more freely than the press of the countries at war.
3. *The Seattle Star* called the epidemic "Spanish influenza".
4. The Germans sowed the flu in the United States from submarines.
5. The 1918 flu began in Kansas.

Practice

1. **The flu in your province.** Search the press of your province (or region) from October 1918, the month with the most deaths from the epidemic in Spain (if there are no newspapers from your province, use the nearest one). Where: <https://prensahistorica.mcu.es>, <https://hemerotecadigital.bne.es> or your region's digital library. And if you want to see how other countries reported it, your teacher has a list of newspaper libraries from all over the world. Note it down in this table:

Date	Newspaper	What it calls it	Who · when and where · what for · for whom	What it tells without meaning to

1. **Which door would you knock on** (archive, newspaper library, museum or interpretation centre) to find your town council's minutes from 1918, an advert for a flu syrup or a thermometer from the time?

2. **An oral source.** Ask someone in your family what they remember of the 2020 lockdown, with their permission; if it's a sad memory, choose another. Note who tells you, when and where they lived it, and what other source you would cross-check it with.

Keep thinking

If you had to keep five things in an archive today so that our time can be understood a hundred years from now, which would you choose? And who should decide what is kept?
